

Gospel Faith and Theology

Twelve Lectures, Delivered at the University
of Copenhagen in the Winter of 1849–50

R. Nielsen

Translated from the Danish by Hans Halvorson

Copenhagen: C. A. Reitzel, 1850

Contents

Preface	5
First Lecture. Introductory Considerations	11
Second Lecture	21
Third Lecture	29
Fourth Lecture	37
Fifth Lecture	39
Sixth Lecture	41
Seventh Lecture	43
Eighth Lecture	45
Ninth Lecture	47
Tenth Lecture	49
Eleventh Lecture	51
Twelfth Lecture	53
Postscript	55
Contents	57

Preface

“If one assumes that all the many pastors here and abroad who deliver and write sermons are believing Christians, how is it then to be explained that one never hears or reads the prayer that lies so near at hand, especially in our times: God in heaven, I thank Thee that Thou hast not required of a human being that he should comprehend Christianity; for if it were required, then I should be the most wretched of all. The more I seek to comprehend it, the more incomprehensible it appears to me, the more I discover the possibility of offense. Therefore I thank Thee that Thou requirest faith alone, and I pray that Thou wilt increase it in me further. This prayer would be entirely correct as orthodoxy, and, granted that it were true in the one praying, it would at the same time be correct irony over the whole of speculation. But is faith to be found upon earth!”

These words of a Christian psychologist who knows “The Sickness unto Death” I use as a preface to the present writing, partly because they have gripped me deeply, partly also because they may best help me to a distinction without which my lectures, in spite of all protests and deprecating assurances, will hardly escape misinterpretation — I mean the distinction between striving for faith and disputing about faith.

To strive for faith is divine; to dispute about faith is human, indeed in part worldly. The reader will thus already be able to discern from this why the above words are not placed as a motto, but are simply set up as a preface: an ingenious motto awakens an expectation; but this preface stands just here in order to turn an expectation away.

However much I have striven in these lectures to avoid everything that could in any way have the appearance of a merely personal quarrel between man and man, I have nevertheless not been able to avoid coming so close to the established order that the reader might, from his point of view, have a kind of right to construe something personal in it. However much I have striven in these lectures from first to last to make it comprehensible that Christianity does not will to be comprehended, I have nevertheless not been quite able to avoid the appearance of setting a concept against a concept, a theory against a theory. For to explain why one cannot explain is after all always to entrust oneself to an explanation; to give grounds why no grounds can be given is, after

all, nevertheless to engage in a grounding.

The present lectures must therefore, in accordance with their design and execution, naturally put up with being reckoned among that sort of attempt in which one does not so much strive for faith as, properly speaking, dispute about faith.

But to dispute about faith is, after all, only human; to strive for faith — that is in truth divine. The latter must on no account be confused with the former; in order to forestall such a confusion, the distinction ought to be brought out as definitely as possible.

As I now sat pondering this distinction and sought a telling expression, those words came to my mind: *“I thank Thee, God in heaven, that Thou hast not required of a human being that he should comprehend Christianity!”*; and the words stirred in my memory and formed for me an image, a speaking image, the image of a Lutheran pastor holding prayer in his congregation.

Since I then wished to present, as in an example, what difference there is between disputing with grounds against grounds and forgetting all finite grounds in a single decisive *personal* ground; between disputing with explanations against explanations and keeping all explanations in a single all-explaining thought; in short, what difference there is between disputing about faith and striving for faith: it then seemed to me that I could choose no better example than the example of this praying pastor, who assuredly will not dispute with anyone about faith, but will strive in all inwardness — and yet with all the world — for faith.

That the striver’s prayer must appear to an outside observer as a “correct irony over the whole of speculation” is comprehensible; it is, after all, no church prayer for “Christian science,” no prayer-day prayer for “the critical introduction”: the irony is then not in the words either, but in the deed, not for the one praying, but for the reflecting observer. The prayer itself is a simple and to that extent also “unscientific” prayer in faith for faith; but the reflecting onlooker hears it at once, where the words of the one praying as it were involuntarily betray a secret acquaintance with “the whole of speculation.” How else should the pastor know within himself that he would be “the most wretched of all” if it were required of him that he should comprehend Christianity; how should just this pastor, among so many ratiocinating, criticizing, aestheticizing pastors who otherwise carry the Church’s “dogmatic” speculations without anyone’s being able to notice on them that the burden weighs; how — I ask — should just this one be able to feel so deeply that on speculation’s terms he would have to become — “the most wretched!” — if he had not himself, and at his own risk, also once allowed himself to look into “the Concept,” and then looked so deeply that with horror he saw — “the possibility of

offense.”

If, then, there really were everywhere by all pastors and in all congregations such striving in faith for faith; if those days returned when the question of the blessed life was the race’s highest question; if the Church’s great jubilee year were now so near that it rang in our ears, as though we already heard the peal of the bells that are to ring it in: yes, then our awakened ones could easily enough dismiss a merely “theoretical school-quarrel,” and refer to life’s “ordeal by fire” those who — “instead of acting accordingly!” — only write about it, insofar as they write about faith. “But” — adds the Christian psychologist — “is faith to be found upon earth!”

If, however, in order to be rid of the “school-quarrel” together with its investigations, one wishes to give the matter a more sober turn and declare that the dispute of principle here announced does not after all signify much, since the victory — if we are finally to be quite candid — has at bottom already been decided beforehand in another place: then from my present standpoint I can of course have not the least objection, but can only rejoice that with so fine a candor one is at last disposed to give truth the honor.

The struggle in which the principle of faith can, with the most intensive power of reflection, make war on dogmatizing speculation has assuredly been fought out in a quite other and higher productivity than the one that can be offered in these discourses. The victory that under the conditions at hand can be won over the age’s aesthetic, metaphysical, systematic, world-historical “delusions of sense” has — so far as I can judge — really already been won by another, and that in the deepest silence, and that so comprehensively, so completely, and on so extensive a scale, that he who won such a victory might surely with right say to himself: “we have more than conquered.”

All the same, there is here still, I suppose — so far as I can see — “ein Aber dabei.”

For with wars and victories things stand somewhat otherwise in the spiritual than in the sensuous world. If a man in the world of the senses has been bodily slain, anyone can easily convince himself that the fallen one really is dead. But in the world of spirit it is otherwise. In the world of spirit a man can sometimes be struck so mortally, and yet so deftly, that not even he himself (much less so many others) rightly notices that anything has actually happened to him. This will be the case precisely in proportion to the greatness of the superiority before which the vanquished has fallen. In the bodily sense it may indeed be ridiculous enough to treat a living man as a ghost, even though rumor has falsely reported him dead; since sensuous appearance is of course the most striking proof that the person is still alive. But in the world of spirit it is otherwise. In the world of spirit, outward appearance and phenomenal well-being stand, not so very

seldom, in an — alas! — entirely inverted relation to the individual's inner health and essential vital force; here, then, what experience will also teach us holds above all: that appearance deceives.

Since now the deceptive appearance is undeniably truth's most dangerous enemy, it becomes in the world of ideas sometimes necessary that one not merely strive for truth and right as in soundless silence, but that one also, with a somewhat louder (and just for that reason somewhat coarser) kind of weapon, dispute at the same time about who it actually is that has conquered in the struggle. If one neglects this last too much, it might easily happen that the higher ideal plenitude of power were — at least for a time — bungled, and a confusion arose in the invisible republic, a confusion far more dangerous to the highest and holiest interests than the confusion that arises in the visible when a besieged fortress lacks a commandant.

So I conclude from this that it might not yet be so entirely without significance to offer a dispute about the principle of faith-knowledge, and I therefore beg the well-disposed reader to be content with my contributions.

How precarious my task nevertheless shows itself to be, everyone must surely admit who thinks the matter over a little more closely.

If there really is to be a dispute here about who it is that has conquered in the struggle, how near at hand does not the misinterpretation lie that the alleged interest in the conception of a principle may after all serve only as one of those pretexts with which a selfish passion would embellish a presumptuous vanity.

Should this misinterpretation (which, however, I do not assume) prove able to force its way through and establish itself as the authentic interpretation: then I must ask that the accusation be advanced so openly and so entirely without all *reservatio mentalis* that it can expressly fall upon me alone.

I put forward this request not in order to affect a heroism I do not possess, but because I regard it as my duty to attempt everything that can in any way contribute to keeping this cause as clean as possible.

That a person who has hitherto lived peaceably, quietly, contentedly, as one who had enough in what was his own, should suddenly rush out and begin to make a noise; that a man who is not otherwise known to have overstepped the bounds of propriety should suddenly appear in motley dress, and in borrowed plumes, and as one who is about to triumph; that an otherwise sober author, to whom the authorities of literature have hitherto not denied a certain cultivation, composure, and thoughtfulness, should all at once take it into his head to comport himself as though he had either been stung

by a fixed idea or else were so far possessed by the demon of vanity that, for want of being something himself, he had to fashion himself after another: that such a thing can happen, how sad, how lamentable! that such a thing really does happen, how sad, how lamentable for the one to whom it happens; but — when it really does happen — it does not after all corrupt the cause, otherwise serious, that such a prostituted person imagines himself to be championing.

If, on the other hand, an author with a somewhat sounder sense set about treating a matter of faith, and yet nevertheless (be it from presumption or from clumsiness) got the higher so entangled in the lower, the religious in the worldly, the matter of principle in the personal, that he not only vexed the established order by his loud-voiced objections (which in the old forms might perhaps otherwise still preserve much that is both noble and good), but even attempted to draw into this relative squabble, in itself utterly subordinate for the religious, “another” as well — “another” who is otherwise never present where trumpets are blown, “another” who otherwise declines every outward advancement, “another” who otherwise by no means covets to be distinguished in wars, if only he may be unnoticed in peace, “another” who otherwise so urgently prays that he as an irrelevance may always be forgotten, and that the thought, only the thought, be remembered: then such an unpleasant proceeding ought assuredly to be rejected from both sides with energetic protest, and every word in the unwarranted attempt annulled, as the court annuls an abusive word.

This and much else I have now discussed and weighed as best I could; but with all this I must still (at least provisionally) confess myself to the opinion that one ought still — *propter iniquitatem temporum!* still — as matters stand *in republica litterarum!* still ought to make an attempt and dispute about faith.

Should it at length come to the point that one did not even find it worth the trouble to dispute about faith, would that then also be a good sign? Would it not rather be a sign that one despised this human struggle because at bottom one did not respect the divine one either; a sign that one found it still less worth the trouble to strive for faith: a sign that faith was no longer to be found upon earth?

The author of the present writing candidly confesses that he does not yet rightly understand, either in word or in deed, how to strive for faith as one ought; but in the hope that the divine may one day fall to his lot, if only he does not, in all too sensuous security, all too much neglect the human, he has wished — if not indeed for the instruction of many, then at least for his own strengthening — to express himself in these lectures concerning the manner in which, at the present time, one — disputes about faith.

Copenhagen, 17 February 1850.

R. Nielsen.

First Lecture

Introductory considerations. Christianity is higher than science, and the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

It is the relation between the faith of the Gospel and theology that is made the object of these lectures. Instead of saying “the faith of the Gospel,” we may at once say “Christianity”; on the other hand, we cannot without further ado make “theology” equivalent to “science.” The question of the relation of the faith of the Gospel to theology thus points provisionally to another and more general question, namely that of Christianity’s relation to science.

As is well known, this relation is conceived very differently at different times and in the different schools, now as a relation of conflict, now again as one of reconciliation.

In the conflict between Christianity and science there are some who go so far as to demand, in the name of science, that Christianity be extirpated, while others, on the contrary, in their zeal to advance Christianity, preach crusades against free science.

With the feeling that there cannot possibly be conflict in the essence of truth, and that the kingdom of truth cannot be divided against itself, men have then again labored to reconcile the contending parties and to bring about a reconciliation by little by little making Christianity scientific and — what comes to the same thing — science Christian.

Which of these endeavors are we now to grant our approval? That is not so easy to say. The whole matter seems so involved that we cannot approve any single one of the attempts indicated here without approving them all, nor reject any single one without rejecting them all. For if those who want the conflict are right, then those who want the reconciliation must be right too. To invite to reconciliation is here the same as to presuppose conflict and to incite to conflict; and conversely, to proclaim conflict is here the same as to invite to reconciliation.

This obscure speech will perhaps clear up and become intelligible when I now set forth my thesis, the two-sided fundamental thought about which these discourses are to move, the thesis, namely, that *Christianity is higher than science, and the faith of the*

Gospel heterogeneous with theology.

The first member of this thesis is hypothetical; the last is categorical.

That Christianity is higher than science cannot be established by any universally valid proof whatsoever. A universally valid proof of this would have to be a scientific one; but a scientific proof that Christianity is higher than science is a contradiction.

In hypothetical form, on the other hand, the proposition can be expressed thus: “if Christianity is what it says itself to be, a revealed truth, then this truth must belong to a sphere higher than the one to which science can raise itself”; and conversely: “if science’s sphere is the highest sphere of the highest truth, then Christianity is lost, and faith abolished.”

That science’s sphere must necessarily be the highest sphere of the knowledge of truth, science cannot prove; for in undertaking to conduct the proof it begins precisely by presupposing the very thing it meant to prove, and does not get outside its own circle.

Since science, then, can neither prove nor disprove Christianity’s truth, we may with every reason combine our two hypothetical propositions in the categorical assertion that Christianity in any case falls outside science, or in other words, that Christianity is heterogeneous with science.

Should this assertion — it is as yet, of course, only an assertion — prove defensible, then three things follow at once:

a) that the vehement conflict between Christianity and science must rest on a misunderstanding; for between heterogeneous powers there can, properly speaking, be no direct conflict. Science as science cannot possibly will to offend Christianity, any more than Christianity can will to hamper or affront science, if it is true that they move in wholly different spheres.

b) that the reconciliation aimed at between Christianity and science must derive from a great misunderstanding. If the conflict is an illusion, the reconciliation must be an illusion too; for a real reconciliation presupposes a real conflict.

c) that the only condition under which science can come to offend and affront Christianity is that it draw Christianity into its own sphere and make it homogeneous with itself; and that theology is consequently, among all the sciences, the only science that can in real earnest offend and affront Christianity.

However offensive this last assertion may perhaps be to many, it follows with unmistakable consistency from the thesis set up. Our investigation thus fastens on the single question whether Christianity really is heterogeneous with every science, by whatever name it may be called, or not.

Christianity proclaims itself, like Judaism, to be a supernatural revelation. God speaks, the miracle happens: with that revelation begins. This beginning is of an unscientific or, if you will, of a supra-scientific nature, and can never become an object of rational grounding.

What Jehovah says and does in the Old Testament is incommensurable with human understanding, and cannot be scientifically grounded; what the Son, “the Only-begotten,” says and does in the New Testament is incommensurable with human understanding, and cannot be scientifically grounded. Moses and the prophets, Christ and the apostles are unscientific, that is to say: supra-scientific figures. None of them comes in the name of science, but they all come forward, and speak and act, in the name of the revealed God.

The miracle is in its essence above, and therefore in its appearance against, the law of nature, and cannot become an object of scientific treatment. Moses strikes the rock, and the spring gushes forth: this fact natural science cannot use, it does not concern it at all. Christ, “the Son of Man,” who goes to meet his suffering and crucifixion, says in the prayer that he had glory with the Father before the world was; this speech philosophy cannot fathom, though it may well see and understand that, if the speech is true, then it must be a supra-scientific, a divine speech.

If revelation is in its principle heterogeneous with science, how then should they come into conflict with one another?

Revelation meets with natural science. Natural science now assures us that if miracles have happened, then they must have happened against the order of nature; but the very same thing is taught by revelation as well. Let natural science then investigate things and discover the laws; let it convince itself in continued inquiry that in nature’s kingdom there is no leap, in the system of laws no place for the supernatural facts; let it go further still, let it with ingenious sagacity gather the manifold analogies of its rich experience in order to make these facts as unreasonable, as improbable, as possible: it will nevertheless still not come to offend Christianity; for Christianity by no means asserts that its facts should accord with the analogies of sensuous experience. Natural science may quite certainly assure us that Christianity’s fact cannot be explained from the connection of natural forces; provided only that it does not assure us of more (and more it is surely not entitled, as science, to assure us of): then it does not offend Christianity. It may even, if it finds itself called upon to do so, take one step further and say that the phenomena of revelation are so contrary to the laws of nature that they appear even absurd in relation to natural phenomena; provided only that it does not say more (and more it is surely not

entitled, as science, to say): it still does not offend Christianity; on the contrary! precisely in this respect there is here the very best understanding between natural science and Christianity, since they both, each in its own measure, at bottom say the very same thing.

Revelation next meets with philosophy, and the horizon widens. Natural science and Christianity can still more easily preserve their heterogeneity; only as it were in passing does natural science graze the precincts of the supernatural, and it feels seldom tempted to press deeper in. It is otherwise with philosophy, which, in testing all things, makes even Christianity itself an object of scientific testing. But is this then permitted? Of course! So liberal is Christianity that it does not even refuse to become an object of philosophy's severest investigation (were it to refuse this, it would offend science). So liberal is Christianity that philosophy is thus allowed to do with it what it will, to declare it comprehensible if it can justify that before science, to reject it as incomprehensible if it can justify that before science, but — be it noted — on one condition: that philosophy with all this does not at the same time take it into its head to want to make itself homogeneous with Christianity.

If this condition is inviolably kept, then there is surely no danger, either for philosophy or for Christianity. If philosophy declares that it has now at last comprehended, or is at any rate well on the way to comprehending, Christianity, there is still no danger, provided it is said only in the name of science. Because Christianity, *scientifically understood*, now and then shows itself to be comprehensible (or at any rate nearly comprehensible), it can for that very reason, *Christianly understood*, be just as fully what it is and what it has always been: wondrous, inconceivable, for us sinful human beings incomprehensible. And because philosophy now and then flares up and wants on science's behalf to remonstrate with the cultivated world that Christianity has now at last shown itself in its true light, as incomprehensible, absurd, and meaningless, there is here nevertheless no real danger, for here at bottom there is no real conflict. No, far from it! Philosophy is now, without perhaps in the heat of it rightly noticing so itself, just now on the way to the very best understanding with Christianity. Christianity has, after all, never promised that it would ever let itself be comprehended (or at any rate nearly comprehended) by philosophy. Christianity is so far from being anxious about this philosophical discovery that on the contrary it congratulates science on the discovery, since it is so glad to see that philosophy, which seeks the truth, should at last come to the knowledge of truth, i.e. to the knowledge that it is heterogeneous with Christianity.

So it is strange enough with this relation between science and Christianity. They quarrel, are reconciled, and quarrel again. According to the prevailing way of seeing

things, one is much troubled about the conflict and ponders deeply on the reconciliation; and the conflict would be still harder, and the reconciliation awaited still more ardently, if the world had not already grown so clever that, with the feeling that at bottom not much comes of either the one or the other, it had already begun to grow a little embarrassed by the whole thing.

Here the matter stands otherwise. Instead of being troubled about the conflict and hoping for the reconciliation, as if it were self-evident that both the conflict and the reconciliation had true validity and exceeding significance, we are now on the contrary so placed that we cannot rightly see what all this fuss actually leads to, since the whole seems to rest on a misunderstanding.

There must, however, be a ground for this misunderstanding; there must be a medium in which the heterogeneous powers meet one another, and engage one another in such a way that they at least acquire the appearance of being homogeneous: where now is this ground? which is this medium? — the existing human being!

In human existence, i.e. in the existing human being, heterogeneous magnitudes are bound into unity. The sensuous and the spiritual, the temporal and the eternal, the natural and the supernatural meet here. It is the human being's general task to relate himself differently to what is different. But when revelation enters in, the difference and the opposition become so strong that the human being, even though he feels within himself that truth is only one and can only be one, is nevertheless led into so deep a dualism of truth that in this existence he must relate himself in entirely different ways to two truths so heterogeneous in existence as: *the truth of revelation and ordinary rational truth*.

From this it is explained how the conflict between Christianity and science arises within Christendom,

The Christian becomes a naturalist; the naturalist is a Christian. Both heterogeneous determinations are combined in one consciousness. The task is that the individual concerned shall now understand how to relate himself Christianly to Christianity and scientifically to science, so that he does not derive conclusions for natural science from Christianity, or conversely draw consequences for Christianity from natural science. But since it is after all the same human being, the same consciousness, that is here to unite the heterogeneous in existential unity: how near at hand does not the temptation then lie to make the heterogeneous magnitudes a little homogeneous, to treat science Christianly and Christianity scientifically, to awaken the discord by striving after the reconciliation.

The Christian becomes a philosopher; the philosopher is a Christian. What matters now is to relate oneself Christianly to Christianity and scientifically to science. But since Christianity proclaims itself as the truth, and since science, *in specie* philosophy, investigates and tests the truth: how near at hand does it not then lie to make Christianity's religious knowledge homogeneous with the philosophical knowledge of Christianity, to reconcile faith with knowledge, and precisely thereby to awaken discord between faith and knowledge!

Natural science and philosophy are, however, with respect to principle and point of departure still so different from Christianity that one easily becomes aware of the heterogeneity, provided the conflict is only carried on consistently. But there is yet another science, a science far more intimately akin to Christianity, a science that with a certain self-regard calls itself the Christian one, a science that claims to have principle and presuppositions in common with Christianity, a science that will absolutely defend Christianity in order to defend itself along with Christianity, a science that presses so close up against Christianity that it is as though they were to live and die together; this science is theology: is Christian theology, then, also heterogeneous with Christianity? — Certainly! Theology as science is assuredly just as heterogeneous with Christianity as any other science. That the relation is here more ambiguous is explained quite simply by the fact that theology is itself an ambiguity.

How matters stand more closely with this ambiguity is not difficult to discover.

Faith cannot be without knowledge. The believer must know what it is that he believes, must be able to give an account, to himself and to others, of the content of his faith and of the communion to which he confesses. Insofar as theology now sets itself exclusively the task of finding out what the Christian is, of developing and explaining what it is that the Church believes and the believer confesses, to that extent theology as theology is doubtless homogeneous with the objective doctrine of Christianity; but this objective doctrine of Christianity is therefore by no means homogeneous with Christianity itself. Insofar as the theologian relates himself Christianly to Christianity, he does not relate himself scientifically; insofar as he relates himself scientifically to Christianity, he does not relate himself Christianly.

The old orthodox theology, which in all points would be conformable to the Church's doctrine, suffered from a great ambiguity. As the comprehensive, complete, and exact presentation of the Church's doctrine, this theology was at bottom nothing other than an articulated confession of the content of faith, and as such not yet science. It was at most only the scientific expression and form of faith-knowledge. But scarcely had it begun in

form to take on the stamp of science, and thus taken the first step toward a reconciliation of Christianity and science, before it also found itself placed in a hard self-contradiction. The content was Christian, the form scientific; this was the contradiction between form and content, a contradiction under which orthodox theology at length succumbed.

Orthodox theology presents every doctrinal proposition thetically, insofar as it presents it in the name of faith; this is the Christian element. But then it also treats every doctrinal proposition hypothetically, insofar as it treats it in the name of learning, investigation, and research; this, then, is the scientific element. Accordingly, every doctrinal proposition comes to be regarded from a double point of view. Christianly understood it belongs to the Church, is exalted above science, and defies every scientific attack. Scientifically understood it stems from theological research, theological discussion, and theological testing, and is thus forfeit to science, and must as such become the object of a new discussion, a new research, a new testing. Under the continued discussion, research now stands against research, testing against testing. If the research is to signify anything for Christianity, it must conform to the Church; if it is to count for anything in science, it must be free and independent of the Church. Theological testing must therefore at one and the same time be both free and unfree, both outwardly dependent and yet outwardly independent; that is a contradiction. The theological doctrinal proposition shows itself here as an ambiguous coin: on the one side, the sign of the Cross! on the other, Minerva's owl! Here it does not even help to say: render unto Caesar what is Caesar's; for this ambiguous coin belongs with equal right both to God and to Caesar.

Theology, which in the beginning would be one with the Church's doctrine, then gradually began, under free research, free discussion, and free testing, to free itself from its original relation of dependence and to transform itself from orthodox into heterodox: the more heterodox it became, the more scientific, and conversely: the more scientific, the more heterodox. Only in the last century has theology grasped itself as an independent science; only in the nineteenth century is it clearly seen that theology is heterogeneous with Christianity.

But Christianity is homogeneous with the faith of the Gospel.

Christianity is only for the believer; theology is only for the knower. The faith of the Gospel lives in the Church; theology lives in science. If they will go on relating themselves as homogeneous, they must work against each other, and will then soon work out their own mutual dissolution.

The faith of the Gospel lives in the Church. What, then, is the Church, and where is it? We answer with the Augsburg Confession: "*The Church is the communion of*

saints, in which the Gospel is rightly preached and the sacraments rightly administered” (*Ecclesia est congregatio sanctorum, in qua evangelium recte docetur et recte administrantur sacramenta*).

But theology, what is it? where is it? Theology is the science that undertakes to subject the Church’s Gospel to a historical-critical testing; the science that as time and occasion allow permits itself to reason for and against the Lord’s sacraments; the “ecclesial” science that may not indeed venture to make itself heard in the church, but may all the more freely make itself heard in the school.

The heterogeneity is now conspicuous.

The Church is that communion of faith in which the Gospel is *rightly preached*. But the Gospel is rightly preached only when it is preached as God’s Word. God’s Word is an infallible, definite, and authoritative Word. Therefore the free preaching of the Word in the congregation always goes back to the revealed original Word; the evangelical sermon must have its text: Holy Scripture supplies the text. The biblical text is read aloud for the congregation’s devotion; devotion is unscientific; devotion knows no criticism: the text read out is in every way infallible and trustworthy, as it ought to be. “So many are the words,” says the pastor, and then he adds a prayer. Thus the evangelical sermon does not begin with ratiocinating criticism, but with prayer and invocation, and only thus can the Gospel be rightly preached.

It is otherwise in theology; for theology is, after all, a science. Science, as science, cannot begin with prayer and invocation. If, then, the Church’s Gospel is to be tested in science, it must be treated in a quite different way. And so it is. In science “the critical introduction” sits with the Gospel before it and interrogates it as to whether it is genuine or perhaps spurious; and the longer one asks, and the more one interrogates, the greater the suspicion one acquires that this Gospel is perhaps after all — spurious. Then “hermeneutics” comes forward and will in the same Gospel scientifically separate the spirit from the letter, the idea from the outer garb, the truth from the representation; and the longer one sifts, the more acutely one separates, the less there comes to be of God’s Word and the more of the human word in the biblical text.

If any conclusion is to be drawn from this, it must surely be the conclusion that what the Church puts into faith, theology converts into doubt.

The Church is that communion of the Spirit in which the *sacraments are rightly administered*. But the sacraments are rightly administered only under the one decisive presupposition that the word of institution is an infallible, divine, miracle-working Word. The Church confesses that Baptism is a bath of regeneration by the Holy Spirit, and the

Lord's Supper the communion of Christ's body and blood for the forgiveness of sins to those who believe. The Church builds on the word of institution, but does not at all apply itself to comprehending the sacrament's mystery. As the Word sounds over Baptism, so it shall be believed — against understanding; as the Word sounds in the Supper, so it shall be believed — against understanding. The miracle, the wondrous efficacy of the means of grace, is not to be explained at all, not comprehended: the appropriation is only in faith.

It is otherwise in theology; for theology is, after all, science. As objective science, theology must of course make the sacraments themselves into critical objects, and then treats the means of grace as means for heightening the scientific luster of idea-knowledge. Then it becomes doubtful again, highly doubtful, how one is to explain to oneself the union of the supernatural with the natural. The difficulty is that one cannot explain it rightly, and yet would so heartily like to have it explained. The longer one goes on explaining, the more doubtful the explanation becomes.

If any conclusion is to be drawn from this, it must surely be the conclusion that what the Church puts into faith, theology converts into doubt.

That theology may in its own way be right in engaging in scientific investigations, and therewith also right in engaging with doubt, shall not be denied; but what must be denied in the most definite terms is that theology should have the right to confound its own task with the Church's. It is no accident that the Church lets everything be decided in faith; neither is it any accident that theology dissolves everything in doubt. The Church tears itself down when it doubts its own authority and gives up faith; theology denies itself when by an authoritative pronouncement it breaks off its investigations in order to arrest doubt.

As doubt cannot be nourished in the Church, so faith cannot be nourished in theology. The Gospel in the Church confirms faith, as faith the Gospel; but doubt in theology conflicts with the Gospel, as the Gospel with doubt.

If any conclusion is to be drawn from this, it must surely be the conclusion that doubt is the Church's enemy, and *the faith of the Gospel heterogeneous with theology*.

Second Lecture

In its conception of the relation between historical and religious faith, theology must separate what in religion is inseparable, and therefore the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

Positive revelation — in Judaism and Christianity — is a historical revelation. As revelation it speaks to the inward human being and presupposes subjective religious faith (*fides religiosa*); as historical revelation it works upon the natural human being's representation through a complex of supernatural but nevertheless actual facts, and thus presupposes at the same time a historical faith (*fides historica*).

He who now relates himself Christianly to Christianity can and may not separate the historical from the religious. In true and living faith both factors must work together without, however, melting together. Since now historical faith, considered by itself, is heterogeneous with subjective religious faith, while the believer nevertheless unites these two heterogeneous determinations in the unity of the faith of the Gospel: it is in consequence exceedingly difficult for the ratiocinating understanding to understand the religious man.

"The sacred facts do not become actual because I believe in them; but conversely, because I know that they are actual, are historical, therefore I believe in them. It has happened that God revealed himself to Abraham; it has happened that God in former times spoke many times and in many ways to the fathers by the prophets; it has all happened, as Scripture witnesses, and therefore I believe in it." Thus speaks the religious man. — " 'It has happened that Jesus Christ, God's only-begotten Son, born of the Father from eternity, was in the fullness of time conceived by the Holy Spirit and born of the Virgin Mary; it has happened that he suffered under Pontius Pilate, that he was crucified and died and was buried and descended into hell and rose again on the third day'; it has all happened, as Scripture witnesses and the Church confesses; and since it has assuredly happened, I believe in it." Thus speaks the religious man.

But for the ratiocinating understanding it is nevertheless very difficult to understand

this speech. It constantly looks as though the religious man were straightforwardly building his faith on a straightforward historical certainty. It looks as though revelation's facts had, in his opinion, so many outward, particular, finite testimonies that no one could reject these facts without rejecting all history. The religious man must then appear to the cultivated (especially the theologically and scientifically cultivated) as an unscientific, uncultivated, and simple person who has so much faith because he knows so little of doubt. Many a one would then perhaps say: "If only I knew that it had all happened as it stands in Scripture; if only I knew that this one thing had happened, that Christ, after he had really died and been buried, rose again on the third day; if only I now knew that this one thing had really happened: yes, then I should surely believe, and in faith become a new and better human being. But who will vouch for us that these narratives are genuine, are reliable and in every way trustworthy? The believer is so sure of his case because he does not know the difficulties at all: he should just begin with the investigations, he should know the objections, he should just try attending a theological course on the critical introduction, and he would then soon enough come round to other thoughts." — Thus judges the ratiocinating understanding; and yet it is a misunderstanding.

The religious man can, if it must be so, very well acquaint himself with the theological difficulties without taking harm to his faith. With "the critical introduction" there is no danger at all. If the three men could go unharmed through the fiery furnace, should the believer then not also be able to go unharmed through "the critical introduction"! If we then meet the religious man as he steps out of criticism's labyrinth, and ask him how his conviction now stands, he answers us that he has indeed now learned much that he did not know before, but that he has thereby only convinced himself the further of what he already knew beforehand: that human beings' doubtful thoughts must bow before God's revealed thoughts, that human beings' works avail nothing against God's works, and all human writings nothing against God's own Holy Scripture; and in speaking thus, he speaks precisely out of his subjective religious faith (*fides religiosa*).

But this speech too is, when we consult the ratiocinating understanding, exposed to misunderstanding. The believer who defies all in reliance on the revealed Word now shows himself as one who is so sure of the historical because he at bottom derives his historical faith from his religious faith. Many a one then perhaps thinks in his own quiet mind: "The believer is right. Nor does the long learned introduction signify much, if only one could believe from the heart. If only I could believe that Christ is risen, then he is assuredly also risen, risen for me. But what use is it to hold to the Gospel of the resurrection when this fact nevertheless stands as a distant and alien event that makes

no impression. If the event could become present to me, if I could get an immediate impression of the risen Savior, like Mary Magdalene when she met him in the garden, or like Thomas when he thrust his finger into the print of the nails and cried out: my Lord and my God! But that is impossible; with the outward fact one cannot begin. The historical is something past, and can no longer become present: one must begin with subjective religious faith.”

Thus judges the reflecting observer, as he as it were inclines toward faith without, however, being able to grasp faith. And yet this too is a misunderstanding. One can in truth as little derive historical faith from religious faith as conversely the latter from the former. When we one-sidedly begin with subjective faith, the religious man holds back, throws himself to the opposite side, and lays an infinite emphasis on the historical. “It has all happened as it stands written, and since it has happened, I believe in the fact.” — If we then take this historical element in and for itself, and let theological criticism shake the fact: then the religious man again strains against it with all his might, throws himself to the other side, appeals to the Spirit’s inner testimony, and now holds the historical fast with infinite passion in subjective, religious faith.

To want to derive religious faith from historical faith is a misunderstanding that leads to a Catholic extreme; to abandon the historical and hold to subjective religious faith is a modern Protestant extreme.

The Catholic Church would by a divine authoritative pronouncement forbid all freer criticism, and comes into conflict with science. By its authoritative pronouncement it shows precisely that it fears science, and is afraid that all is not quite right with the historical. This fear awakens suspicion; this suspicion undermines faith.

Modern Protestantism sets criticism free; criticism dissolves the historical, and undermines faith. For if “the critical introduction” is to have the least influence on religious conviction; if from criticism’s results one may draw a single conclusion for or against faith, then it is assuredly impossible for subjective faith, at least at that moment, to believe religiously in Holy Scripture.

Whence now does this come? Doubtless from the fact that in Catholicism as in Protestantism one has made *Christianity homogeneous with science, the faith of the Gospel homogeneous with theology*.

If Catholicism were conscious that Christianity and theology are heterogeneous, it would not need at all either to forbid or to restrict free criticism. If Protestantism fully saw that the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with science, the Church would not need at all to heed the critical dissolution.

The delusion maintains itself by the fact that the historical and the subjectively religious work together in the unity of faith, notwithstanding that the historical, as historical, is nevertheless heterogeneous with the subjectively religious.

Religious faith cannot draw a single breath without supporting itself on its historical presupposition. This Catholicism has seen quite rightly, and therefore it inculcates the historical. But now the Church's doctrine is at the same time to be theology, and theology is to secure the broad historical foundation (of Scripture and tradition) by historical testimonies and historical learning, is by scientific research to raise objective, historical certainty to absolute, incontrovertibly decisive certainty. That theology cannot do, it is far beyond its powers; so one takes refuge in the ecclesial authoritative pronouncement, and the Church tyrannizes over science.

In place of the ecclesial authoritative pronouncement, Protestantism sets free subjective faith (*fides religiosa*). The Protestant consciousness has seen quite rightly that the historical is heterogeneous with the religious, that everything at last depends on the Spirit, the living Spirit indwelling the congregation, and not on a greater or lesser sum of historical, long since past events. Against this general principle we make no general objection either; only it depends on how it is applied in practice.

The false application is that in the name of faith and on faith's behalf one separates what faith cannot and may not separate. — One takes the historical by itself and makes it the object of a critical-scientific treatment. "The Bible is a collection of various writings of antiquity, written at various times by various authors under various conditions." Thus "the critical introduction" begins. Against this there is nothing to object, if "the critical introduction," in beginning its historical-critical course on these "writings of antiquity," will then at once declare that the scientific investigation signifies nothing, nothing whatever, for the faith of the Gospel and the Church's doctrine. But that "the critical introduction" will assuredly not declare. It rather lets it be understood that these investigations are important, very important, not only — what we readily grant — for the sake of learned science itself, but also important, indeed in all their particulars and their whole prolixity highly important, for all the Church's future teachers, for the pastors to be. "The critical introduction" will therefore (mediately or immediately) have a voice in deciding what the religious conception of Holy Scripture ought to be.

"The critical introduction" thinks after this fashion: let us, with the reservation of a certain general faith, first get the purely historical critically settled, and then we can always afterward draw conclusions from it for our religious conviction. But this is an entirely false presupposition. The law is that historical faith point for point is to

be maintained and borne by inward, strong, subjective, religious faith; the law is that historical faith perishes on the instant when it is abandoned by the religious. This law is violated by the critical introduction. The proof of this is that criticism's objective, or rather half-objective and half-subjective, settlement runs out into endless doubt.

Historical faith is in its essence relative, and goes only upon the probable; but the merely probable can continually be converted and weakened into the improbable. Subjective religious faith is the decisive, the unconditional, the overreaching, which grasps the absolute. But in religious speech it nevertheless looks as though both were equally absolute; for the religious man does not separate them: only in reflection do they become separated.

The relation can therefore be expressed thus:

Subjective religious faith rests upon the historical as upon its foundation, but itself bears the foundation upon which it rests.

Having thus determined the relation in general, let us then go more closely into the particular, and consider, for example, *the theologians' dispute over the Apostles' Creed*.

If only one would be content to relate oneself Christianly to Christianity and scientifically to science, then the Church could at once, for its part, end the dispute by vouching for the historical validity of its confession of faith; but now one is (if for nothing else, then for theology's sake) also to relate oneself scientifically to the Apostles' Creed: now the critical introduction begins again. — "Can one then really believe so unconditionally in this symbol as the Church assumes? Does it then come word for word from Christ himself or from his apostles? Has it not rather formed itself gradually? Is not one article taken up against the Gnostics, another against the Apollinarians? Is "the descent into hell" genuine? Let us compare the various copies and recensions. Is not the recension found in Rufinus, after all, remarkably divergent from other corresponding recensions?"

Now a mass of difficulties arises, a mass of misgivings; now there is strife here as for life and death (for here the strife is about the Church's very foundation); now the theologians divide into two ranks; now it goes: with grounds — for and against, witnesses and testimonies — for and against, interpretations of these witnesses and these testimonies — for and against, interpretations again of these interpretations — for and against. A scientific vapor of opinions and pieces of reasoning envelops the contenders! It is an involved strife; for theology carries on not only the strife, but at the same time the history of the strife; whereupon strife can again arise about how the history of the strife ought properly to be presented and judged: it goes on into infinity!

What, then, is the Church now to do with all this strife? Is it to forbid it by an

authoritative pronouncement? That would be Catholic, and is besides in Protestantism entirely impossible. Is the Church then perhaps to expect some advantage from the strife's final settlement? No, by no means! If the Church at any moment supports itself on a scientific defense, it must also put up with suffering under a scientific attack. If the Church will share theology's victories, it must also put up with sharing theology's defeats; but this conflicts both with the Church and with Christianity. Rather, the Church shall quite calmly rely on its own authority, let the strife go its scientific course, and only see to it that science keeps to what is its own.

Scientific criticism is in no way able to deprive the Church of its confession of faith. The objections, when pressed to the very furthest, cannot after all carry it further than to establishing an improbability with respect to the symbol's genuineness. When criticism has said: this confession of faith's origin from Christ and the apostles is to me in the highest degree improbable: then doubting, contradicting criticism has said the last word, and can say no more. But about this alleged improbability two things are to be noted:

a) The highest degree of improbability, which is otherwise decisive for every other historical-critical testing (when *fides historica* is taken in and for itself), will in this case not suffice. In the communication of the confession of faith the supernatural is, after all, at work. The confession of faith has its origin from inspiration, and points to the miracle. But the miracle itself belongs to the improbable. To reject the symbol on the ground of an improbability is therefore a contradiction: the miracle will continually weaken and disturb the critical attack.

b) The criticism of attack is besides weakened in another way. Those who defend the symbol find just as many grounds and testimonies for their assumption as those who attack it. So the strife is in an unceasing fluctuation of probability and improbability; here there is no settlement, the settlement is religious: faith or unbelief. The Church, which speaks the language of faith, therefore does right in maintaining the confession without heeding scientific criticism.

If we now place the believer in the midst between criticism's doubt and the Church's confession, how will he then relate himself? Differently, of course, to what is different: Christianly to Christianity and scientifically to science.

The believer may well take part in the theologians' critical dispute over the symbol, and reason for and against, like all the other critics (for insofar as he relates himself scientifically to science, he is of course also a critic). But wherein does he as a believer then differ from the theologian? The theologian expects, after all, that at last in time some great Christian-ecclesial result is to be brought out of the long critical investigation; but

that the believer does not expect at all. In relation to the Church's earnestness, the whole prolix strife is to him only as a humanly entertaining play of thought. The Christian settlement is in faith, not in theology. This will also emerge from a consideration of the strife's inner character.

Those who attack the symbol bring forward, say, 3 grounds, 3 proofs against it (whereby improbability provisionally gains the preponderance). Then the defenders come forward with 4 grounds, 4 proofs for it (and at the same moment probability rises). After some time has elapsed the attackers find out 7 grounds and 7 proofs (improbability has the preponderance again), and so on.

The religious man, who sees and understands what comes of such proceedings, is after all perfectly right when he says to himself: if I am to wait until this dispute comes to an end, then I shall have to wait until doomsday; but if I am to break off at the 20th ground because a counter-ground follows, or at the 21st proof because a counter-proof follows, then I may just as well break off at the first and only decisive ground, namely the one that lies in the Church's testimony.

Who, then, is here the more intelligent, the believer or the theologian? I should think the believer, and I venture besides to establish it by a mathematical example. There are, as is well known, infinite fractions; to want by continued division to exhaust such an infinite quotient in finite numbers is proof of mathematical ignorance. But so naive is "the critical introduction" in all its acuteness that it supposes it can exhaust an infinite quotient in finite numbers.

Yet there is still a difficulty remaining, not for faith, not for the Church, but for ratiocinating reflection, for theology.

"Let us grant," one says, "let us just grant that the Apostles' Creed is according to its content — that is to say, according to its general content — both apostolic and fundamentally Christian; but then no one can deny either that this divine original Word is expressed in human words, articulated in finite articles and finite propositions. These articles and propositions can surely not, word for word, be entirely unimprovable or unalterable. Every time the symbol is translated from one language into another, the individual propositions and expressions do after all always undergo some alteration. The symbol is besides far from containing all the important chief propositions of faith, and an article more or less can therefore not possibly be decisive for one's eternal salvation. Or should a believing Christian not be able to be saved because he was baptized on a confession of faith from which the descent into hell happened to be left out?"

Thus reasons theological criticism. But however much prestige this reasoning may

procure for itself in science, it is nevertheless, in relation to the Church, an entirely subtle and sophistical piece of reasoning.

When the criticizing theologian asks whether a single article or a single word in the confession makes any difference one way or the other, we must involuntarily think of the sophist who asks whether a single hair torn out makes a man bald, or a single grain a heap. Instead of engaging in sophisms, the Church ought for its part immediately to stop the endless reasoning, and lead the principle-less investigation back to its principle. The question of principle is not this, how many letters or how many propositions or how many articles can be thought of as left out of the confession of faith without harm to salvation; the question of principle is whether a critical separation of the divine and the human in the Church's original Word can take place without danger to faith. This question has already been answered with a No. In the original Word of the confession, God's Word is not to be separated from the historical. — Thus runs the Church's language: "As no one can eat of bread in general, but of *this* bread, *this* consecrated bread, which we break; and as no one can drink of a cup in general, but of *this* cup, *this* cup of blessing, which we bless: so too can no one be baptized upon a Christian confession in general, or in a religious communion in general, or by a minister of the Word in general; but this is the original Word's decisive authority, that he who is received into the bosom of the congregation must be baptized upon *this* confession, in *this* communion, in *this* church, by *this* pastor, on *this* day. This is the original Word's decisive authority, that the eternal here unites itself with the temporal, the divine with the human, in indissoluble definiteness; here too it holds good: 'what God hath joined together, let no man put asunder.'" Against this language of the Church, theological reasoning is vain and powerless! What critic, pray, has authority to take away a single article of the Church's confession? and what theologian, pray, has authority to insert a single article into this confession? — The faith of the Gospel joins what theology separates, and why? *Because the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.*

Third Lecture

In its conception of the confession of faith and of Holy Scripture, scientific theology must consistently go on working against faith; for the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

To want at one and the same time, in one and the same instant, to relate oneself believingly and yet scientifically to one's confession of faith is a contradiction. Insofar as I am in the confession, I am outside science; insofar as I am in science, I am outside the confession. To be great in the confession is something quite other than to be great and distinguished in science. The fisherman from Bethsaida was nothing at all in science; but the fisherman from Bethsaida nevertheless became great in the confession when he bore witness to the Master and said: *Thou art Christ, the Son of the living God.* And Christ, who hears his confession and knows what a confession means, does not answer him either in the language of science, does not place himself in a critical-scientific relation to him, but strengthens his faith, rejoices over his confession and calls him blessed: "*Blessed art thou, Simon Bar-Jona; for flesh and blood hath not revealed it unto thee, but my Father, which is in heaven.*"

But — it is many years since the first confession of Christ was heard in the world; in these many, many years one has then gradually fallen into the habit of relating oneself scientifically to Christianity and theologically-critically to the confession.

When, then, the critical introduction now takes the confession before it, holds it up to science's light, and inspects it from every side, it acquires (besides the misgivings already adduced) yet another scruple, which we must here heed all the more since this scientific scruple at the same time seems to be a religious scruple.

One reasons roughly thus:

"If the believer may on no account separate the confession's divine content from the human word and letter, then he may not have any inkling either that this human word can be subject to any alteration whatsoever. Let one judge the critical investigation as one will: he who has once been touched by doubt cannot arbitrarily break off and

return to the first simplicity. If the religious man once learns that there is more than one draft, more than one recension of the Apostles' Symbol, and if he is nevertheless to be bound to the confession's word and letter: then he must live in constant anxiety that he has not yet found the right original text; who can then blame him for seeking by continued inquiry to arrive at the greatest possible certainty about the original, for taking an interest, say, in knowing whether "the descent into hell" is originally genuine or a later addition. Suppose that this article were spurious, suppose that Christ did not descend into hell, suppose that the representation of this descent into the realm of the dead were only to be understood figuratively of Christ's actual death; then the believer who clings to the confession's word comes to believe an untruth, comes in his blind zeal to hold fast to the apostolic precisely to accept an unapostolic representation." —

This solicitude and concern of criticism for the purity of the Church's doctrine is, however fair and pleasing it may look at first glance, nevertheless of a very subtle and sophistical nature. From fear that something might possibly have crept in here in the historical (in *fides historica*) that was not purely and genuinely historical; from fear that this something should then in turn corrupt the Church and harm faith, theological criticism will benevolently seduce both the Church and the believer into making a separation that annihilates faith, namely a theoretical separation of the divine and the human in the confession's original Word. The theologian will therefore help the believer! Yes, indeed he will help him; but the help is somewhat ambiguous, the help is such as if he would help him out of the water into the fire.

The danger that a spurious article should, despite the Church's vigilance, have entered into the confession of faith is, religiously regarded, nothing beside the danger of entering upon a ratiocinating separation of the inseparable, and thereby losing faith.

In reliance on the word of the Church and of the Gospel, the believer goes with his confession confidently through the world, into eternity, before that Judge who knows all things and judges righteously. And when the human being's soul then stands before that Judge who knows all, both the historical and the non-historical and the supra-historical: then it will surely appear where the danger is and wherein it consists. The mortal danger is then not that here, in the clarity of the light, it should suddenly be discovered that the confession had by a human error acquired one article too many. No, the danger is quite another, the mortal danger is that the human being has not lived in faith in his confession as he ought. If only he has lived in faith, striven for the confession and striven the good strife: then the Judge will surely not reproach him that there is one article too many in the confession with which he comes, but will take him into grace

and call him blessed, as he called his beloved disciple blessed when he first heard his confession. But woe to the soul that comes in doubt with a doubtful confession. “The critical introduction” cannot, after all, help him when the Judge demands a reckoning. Or what use would it be if this doubting soul now began to excuse itself and say: “Lord, there were so many editions and so many recensions of our ecclesial confession of faith down there, so many mutually divergent and differing recensions, that at last I did not know which I should choose; criticism then advised me to separate the divine from the human, in Thy confession as in Thy Gospel. And so I followed criticism’s advice, and so I entered into the scientific investigations, and by my scientific investigations I came further and further into doubt, and so my faith languished, for at last I no longer knew — alas! — what I really ought to believe.” Will not then the Judge of conscience answer this doubter and say: “Thou fool, why didst thou not believe the Church’s testimony, as it runs word for word? why wouldst thou not understand that my Word is an inseparable unity of divine and human word, as I myself am an inseparable unity of God and man?”

—

If anyone will absolutely misunderstand this statement, let him simply give the matter the turn as though I were hereby aiming to make science hated and to outlaw criticism; for that is truly a great misunderstanding. So far is it from being the case that in this attempt I have intended to abolish criticism, that on the contrary I have wished to help theological science to a most needful and entirely indispensable criticism: the criticism whereby one separates the real danger from the imagined.

When Luther strove for his doctrine of the Lord’s Supper, ratiocinating criticism was already in full swing, and would with all its might make a divorce between the divine and the human in the word of institution. But Luther strove for his text, for he strove in faith. “These words of institution” — he says — “bring it about that the bread is his (Christ’s) body, and the wine his blood. He who now eats this bread, he eats Christ’s true body; whoever drinks this cup drinks Christ’s true blood, be he worthy or unworthy. That one shall firmly believe; for the dear Christians shall do God the honor of confessing that what God says, that he can also do, as St. Paul writes of Abraham that he did (Rom. 4:21). Whoever will be a Christian, he shall not do as our fanatics and mutineers, who trouble themselves about how it could be that the bread is Christ’s body and the wine Christ’s blood. They will measure and comprehend God with their reason, and because it does not accord with their reason, they suppose God cannot do it either. But what is this, that one has already troubled oneself about it so long? Though one tore oneself apart, one would still not be able to comprehend God with human reason; for our Lord God is not

such a God as lets himself be measured, comprehended, and grasped by human reason, and his works and words are not such works and words as should be subject to human reason.”

“Let us suppose that our text and understanding were also uncertain and dark, as it is not, just as theirs is (the Zwinglians’ text and understanding); then you still have the glorious defiant advantage that you can with a good conscience stand on our text, and say thus: If I must and am to have an uncertain, dark text and understanding, then I will rather have the one that is spoken by the divine mouth itself than have the one that is spoken by a human mouth; and if I am to be deceived, then I will rather be deceived by God, if that were possible, than by human beings; for if God deceives me, he will surely answer for it and give me redress. Human beings cannot give me redress, but lead me to hell. Such defiance the fanatics cannot have; for they cannot say: I will rather stand on the text that Zwingli and Oecolampadius utter in discord than on the text that Christ himself utters in concord.”

“Therefore you can gladly say to Christ both in your death and at the last judgment thus: My dear Lord Jesus Christ! There has arisen a quarrel about thy words in the Supper: some will have it that they are to be understood otherwise than they run. Since they teach me nothing certain, but only confuse me and make me uncertain, and can in no way either will or prove their text: so I have abided by thy text, as the words run. If there is anything dark in it, then thou hast willed to have it dark; for thou hast given no other explanation of it, nor commanded one to be given. Likewise one finds in no writing or language that is should mean *signify*, or *my body sign of the body*.”

“Should there now be a darkness in it, then thou wilt surely bear with me that I do not hit upon it, just as thou didst bear with thine apostles that they did not understand thee in many respects; as when thou didst proclaim thy suffering and resurrection, and they nevertheless kept the words as they ran, and did not make others of them. Just as thy dear mother also did not understand when thou saidst to her (Luke 2:49): I must be about my Father’s business, and she nevertheless simply kept the words in her heart and did not make others of them. So I too have abided by these words: *This is my body, this is my blood*.”

What a contradiction it is to want at one and the same time to relate oneself both Christianly and scientifically to Christianity becomes (if possible) still clearer to us when we look to the theologians’ involved dispute about Holy Scripture. Let us first consider the dispute in its generality, in order the better to be able to assess the principle that develops in its particulars.

That the Church has its Holy Scripture; that it regards this Scripture as a Scripture breathed in by God, inspired, so that Scripture's human words are at the same time God's Word, no one can deny who does not straightforwardly wish to deny the existence of the Church and of Christianity.

The Church therefore has its Holy Scripture, and posits a difference of quality between this holy, inspired Scripture and every other writing. Inspiration is Scripture's quality. This quality is inculcated with so great emphasis by the Reformers that the validity of our evangelical Church's confessional writings is even made straightforwardly dependent on Holy Scripture. The Augsburg Confession, which is after all regarded as our Church's palladium, is built upon Scripture; it is therefore not to hold in and for itself alone; but it is to hold *quia et quatenus*, *because* and *insofar as* it accords with the Word revealed in Holy Scripture.

The theologians, who at bottom wrangle about everything, dispute about everything and doubt about everything, are of course still in much doubt and dispute about how this *quia* and *quatenus*, this *because* and this *insofar as*, is properly to be explained.

If we consider the relation from the standpoint of the Church and of the faith of the Gospel, the explanation is easy to find out. When the evangelical Church confesses of its confessional writings that they are to hold only *insofar as* (*quatenus*) they agree with Holy Scripture: then it has by no means been the Church's meaning to abandon these confessional writings to theology's critical-scientific treatment. We know how it went with Melancthon, who attempted to alter the 10th article on the Lord's Supper. Melancthon was the most respected theologian of his time, indeed the man who had himself drawn up the Confession; but the faith living in the Church set itself against the theologian, and the theologian had to give way. The Church could not at any moment doubt that the confession must be true and trustworthy (how, indeed, should a church body be able to come forward with a confession doubtful by its own admission); the Church declares that the Confession stands fast *because* it accords with Scripture. In this *quia*, in this *because*, lies unconditional certainty; but in this *quia*, *because*, there is at the same time expressed the thoroughgoing difference of quality that obtains between Holy Scripture and the Confession. Scripture is inspired, the Confession is not. This difference does not bear most closely on the content (for the essential content must at bottom be the same in the Confession as in Scripture, since the Confession has its content from Scripture); but the difference of quality points to the connection between the divine content and the human word. In Scripture this connection is absolutely indissoluble, for Scripture is holy and inspired; in the Confession, on the other hand, the connection is

not absolute: the same content can be expressed in other, perhaps more adequate, words and propositions. Individual articles can be added or, in order to make the sense still clearer, expressed in other words, should the Church at some time under other conditions find itself called upon to do so. Thereby the expression *quatenus*, *insofar as*, acquires its significance. Of the relation between Scripture's word and Scripture's content, on the other hand, no *insofar as*, no *quatenus*, holds. In Scripture itself the connection of the divine and the human (content and form, meaning and expression) is in every way so perfect, so absolute, so infallible and unalterable that no separation can be thought: Scripture is holy and inspired; every word in the canonical Scripture is a Word of God, breathed in by God.

But when this conception is made to hold in all its strictness, everyone surely understands that it is a religious and not a scientific conception. The contradiction, the glaring contradiction that lies in wanting at one and the same time to relate oneself religiously and yet scientifically to Holy Scripture, shines out from orthodox theology's own history.

There is in our Church's history a period that has rightly been called the bibliolatrous period. Bibliolatry, idolatrous Bible-worship, is quite a telling expression for the unblessed attempt to relate oneself at one and the same time, in the same respect and in equal degree, both objectively-scientifically and subjectively-religiously to Holy Scripture.

For the objective scientific observer the Bible is an outward object; for the religious man it is a holy object: for the scientifically religious man the Bible is therefore an outward holy object, i.e. an object of idolatrous worship.

So there sits the scientific but nevertheless orthodox Protestant, and looks worshipfully at his Bible, just as the scientific but nevertheless orthodox Catholic looks worshipfully up to his Pope. It is of no use at all that a Protestant critic subjects the Pope to a scientific assessment and in this assessment lays bare his faults and sins: the orthodox Catholic believes in the Pope just as fully, the orthodox Catholic will be sure to defend the Pope's objective infallibility with objective grounds; for the orthodox Catholic worships the Pope. Just as little does it help that a Catholic critic — to the advantage of the one saving Church — sets about reasoning against the Bible and laying bare its human imperfections: the orthodox Protestant scientifically rejects every scientific objection; the orthodox Protestant will be sure to go on defending the Bible's objective infallibility with objective grounds; for the orthodox Protestant worships the Bible.

In Protestantism's orthodox theology the objectively scientific theory of inspiration was developed with bibliolatrous consistency. The Bible was not merely inspired, but

grammatically-linguistically inspired to the last dot and tittle. The Holy Spirit had expressly dictated to the holy men every word, every letter they were to write. The holy men were therefore also called “God’s scribes,” “God’s pens” (*notarii Dei, calami Dei*).

In the theory of inspiration, then, the faith of the Gospel and theology were to have found their essential and indissoluble point of union; but behold! in the theory of inspiration lay precisely the germ of their future separation.

In holding fast Scripture’s quality in the unity of the divine and the human effected by inspiration, the faith of the Gospel is at the same time willing to acknowledge the difference and to conceive Scripture’s human side as it factually shows itself. Faith does not at all aim at comprehending the relation, but thanks God that it can appropriate the content: faith relates itself subjectively to the inspired original Word.

But orthodox theology, which related itself objectively and scientifically, now wanted at the same time to draw scientific conclusions from the religious presupposition, and thereby brought about its own fall.

The religious unity of the divine and the human in Scripture’s word learned theology then in the first place conceived as a *grammatical* unity. Thus arose the dispute about the inspiration of the vowel points in the Old Testament (the Buxtorfs — Ldv. Capellus). In this dispute orthodoxy suffered a great defeat.

The religious unity of Scripture’s divine content and human form learned theology next conceived as a linguistic-aesthetic unity. “If the New Testament was breathed in by the Holy Spirit, then the New Testament’s Greek” — so the theologians supposed — “must also be the purest and most perfect Greek.” Thus arose the dispute about the Greek style of the New Testament (Seb. Pfochen, Siegm. Georgi — Thom. Gataker, Salmasius, Sturz and others). In this dispute orthodoxy suffered a great defeat.

With respect to the orthodox theory of inspiration we must therefore expressly note: a) that it dissolved in its own consequences; b) that it weakened the independence of the Church and of faith; c) that it paved the way for negative criticism.

Once criticism had first broken through orthodoxy’s theological rampart, it gradually tore down the Church’s remaining religious presuppositions, according as it found that they stood in its way. Under the pretense that the historical facts were at bottom inessential for faith, criticizing theology understood how by manifold turns of phrase to fob off the general feeling of piety, and could then all the more freely place itself in a purely scientific relation to Scripture.

The still moderate, half-scientific and half-consistent theology is a masked freethinking; resolute freethinking is theology’s scientific consequence.

In theology's dispute with the modern consciousness the theologians suffer day by day one defeat after another, come deeper and deeper into the difficulties, deeper and deeper into doubt.

Doubtless considered theology can still beat back many an attack that an over-heated criticism may have directed against the genuineness of one or another biblical writing; but what is thereby won? Can the theologian ever bring it to the point where he dares to say: "The genuineness of this disputed writing is settled, now at last settled once and for all"? — By no means! such an assertion is unscientific, and conflicts straightforwardly with the conditions of historical faith (*fides historica*). The theologian brings it at the very most only to a halt, a provisional halt: "this writing's spuriousness is not yet settled!" But if the genuineness is not quite settled either, then it is after all subject to doubt; but if it is subject to doubt, it is after all lost for faith; for faith goes out where doubt comes in.

So now the freethinker and the theologian contend — under the same presupposition, under the same scientific principle: only the language and the mood differ. The freethinker is resolute: "The spuriousness is settled!" The theologian is irresolute: "The spuriousness is not yet settled." The freethinker has in the name of science exchanged faith for unbelief. The theologian has in science lost faith, and is despite all scientific exertion no longer able to raise his doubt to faith. The freethinker relates himself non-religiously to Scripture; the theologian can never bring it to the point where he, as a scientific theologian, relates himself religiously.

If the theologian will hold to the Church, he must openly break with science; if he will hold to science, he must openly break with the Church: this is the final dilemma.

If the Church is to maintain its independence, it must guard itself in equal degree against the theologian's defense and the freethinker's attack. The negative weapon with which the Church defends itself is the fundamental thought *that Christianity is higher than science, and the faith of the Gospel heterogeneous with theology.*

Fourth Lecture

For scientific theology the Bible is a historical document of antiquity whose heterogeneous constituents must submit to ratiocinating criticism; for the believing conception the Bible's wondrous content is exalted above criticism, since it is impossible for the observer to relate himself critically and ratiocinatingly to the miracle: the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

Fifth Lecture

Theological interpretation of Scripture misconstrues the peculiar character of revelation, and dissolves the content of faith into science's explanation; religious interpretation of Scripture reduces science to a means for a believing appropriation of the revealed Word: the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

Sixth Lecture

The theological interpreter of Scripture appeals to the Bible's inspiration in the whole, but may on no account acknowledge its inspiration in the particular. Since there is thus doubt about every particular, there must of course also be doubt about the whole: for the theologian the Bible's inspiration is an empty phrase. The evangelical interpreter of Scripture, who in accordance with the law of existence everywhere sees the whole concentrated in the particular, conceives every single passage of Scripture as inspired, under the ecclesial presupposition that the whole Bible is inspired: the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

Seventh Lecture

In the treatment of sacred history — “the Life of Jesus” — the theologian will work against the freethinker; but the scientific criticism on which he proceeds shows plainly enough that in principle he is at one with the freethinker. The believer, who in his conception of the Gospels’ Christ holds exclusively to religious-ethical criticism, is in principle at one with the evangelists: the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

Eighth Lecture

The half-philosophical image of Christ that the speculating dogmatician conjures up consists in a mystical fusion of the scientific and the religious, and is on that account so infinitely different from the evangelists' Christ that it falls even outside the religious-ethical horizon: the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

Ninth Lecture

Theology's half-speculative dogmatics cannot justify its ecclesial significance from the history of the Church, since the history of the Church proves, on the contrary, how dogmatic prejudices have in this respect harmed the Church, and what a thoroughgoing opposition there is here between theological and ecclesial dogmatics. Theological dogmatics must fall before the proposition that Christianity is a paradox: the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

Tenth Lecture

According to the method now in force, theoretical theology finds itself in an evident disproportion to religious practice; in order to maintain the principle of faith, the formation of pastors must emancipate itself from theory, for the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

Eleventh Lecture

Theoretical theology must relate itself skeptically to Christianity's revealed truth; practical theology, which in imagined existence labors to solve the Christian tasks, must end by dissolving itself: the faith of the Gospel is heterogeneous with theology.

Twelfth Lecture

If practical theology does not understand how to remove its theoretical semblance, this semblance will mislead religious formation still far more than open theory does. Theoretical theology, which cannot deny its essential difference from religious practice, will, by furthering its scientific interests in the spirit of science, go on working fruitfully and formatively upon all who in the inwardness of faith recognize that Christianity is higher than science, and the faith of the Gospel heterogeneous with theology.



Postscript

Contents
